that are foreign to the host and not to those of host itself. This ability to distinguish foreign molecules from self is another fundamental feature of the immune system. However, occasionally, it fails to make its distinction and reacts destructively against the host's own molecules; such autoimmune diseases can be fatal to the organism.

Almost all the macromolecules e.g. proteins, polysaccharides, nucleic acids, etc., as long as they are foreign to recipient organism can induce immune response. Any substance capable of eliciting immune response is called an **ANTIGEN** (**ANTI**body **GEN**erator). There are two broad classes of immunity responses namely, innate immunity and acquired immunity **(Fig. 8.1)**.

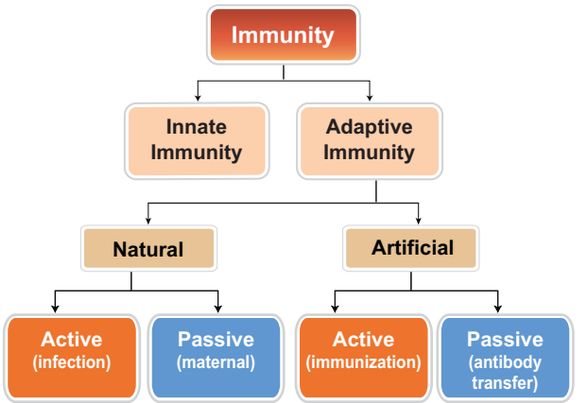


Fig. 8.1 Immune system

8.2 Innate immunity

Innate immunity is the natural phenomenon of resistance to infection which an individual possesses right from the birth.

Table 8.1 Innate immunity- types and mechanisms

Type of innate immunity	Mechanism
1. Anatomical barriers	
Skin	Prevents the entry of microbes. Its acidic environment (pH 3-5) retards the growth of microbes.
Mucus membrane	Mucus entraps foreign microorganisms and competes with microbes for attachment.
2. Physiological barriers	
Temperature	Normal body temperature inhibits the growth of pathogens. Fever also inhibits the growth of pathogens.
Low pH	Acidity of gastric secretions (HCl) kills most ingested microbes.
Chemical mediators	Lysozyme acts as antibacterial agent and cleaves the bacterial cell wall. Interferons induce antiviral state in the uninfected cells. Complementary substances produced from leucocytes lyse the pathogenic microbes or facilitate phagocytosis.
3. Phagocytic barriers	Specialized cells (Monocytes, neutrophils, tissue macrophages) phagocytose, and digest whole microorganisms.
4. Inflammatory barriers	Tissue damage and infection induce leakage of vascular fluid, containing chemotactic signals like serotonin, histamine and prostaglandins. They influx the phagocytic cells into the affected area. This phenomenon is called diapedesis.

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